



Draw Great Graphs with Open Flash Charts

Part—1

Ever wondered how those beautiful graphs are created, or those pie charts, line charts and bar graphs? What if you had the power to build those without having to spend much, the open source way? Well, all you need is Open Flash Charts!

Open Flash Charts (OFC) is an open source charting tool that lets you draw amazing Flash-based graphs on your website. First, let us discuss how to set up the Flash charting component and what the pre-requisites are. Then we will move on to drawing a sample bar graph.

The basics

To get up and running with OFC, first download the code library files from the official site. Visit <http://teethgrinder.co.uk/open-flash-chart-2/downloads.php> and download the Version 2 'Lug Wyrn Charmer' zip file. This contains the code library for PHP, Ruby, Perl, Python, Java and even .NET, as you can read on the site. We will concentrate on PHP in this article. Unzip the file to the root folder of your site. Once that's done, we are ready to draw the first graph.

Drawing graphs

Let us try to draw a bar chart that fetches data from a MySQL database. Since the data will be passed to the graph from the database once the graph is completed, it will automatically change, depending on the data in the database, thus providing complete abstraction for the users. To draw the graph, you need to first decide on the values to be plotted on the X and Y axes. For our sample graph, let us consider a student's marks table as the data to be plotted on the graph (see table below). Let us plot each student's

marks against the total marks, so there will be four bars in the chart, each corresponding to a student and the marks obtained by him.

Name	Class	Marks
Ramesh	10	75
Ram	10	45
Rajesh	10	85
Raghav	10	99

To start plotting the graph, first define a data file, which can fetch data from the database. The data file has an SQL query to actually fetch the data, which is in the form of an array. Now, let us look at a sample data file (*BarGraphDataFile.php*) to understand how it is constructed. The code in this article can be downloaded from <http://goo.gl/WS3tt>.

```
<?php
$die = false;
$link = @mysql_connect('localhost', 'root', '') or ($die = true);
if($die)
{
    echo '<h3>Database connection error!!!</h3>';
}
```